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UNFINISHED WORK AT MAMALLAPURAM OR,
WHAT IS AN INDIAN ART OBJECT?

One of the enduring puzzles about the ancient monuments of Mamallapuram is why so much of the work at the site seems to be incomplete.¹ Indeed, it can be argued that every ancient monument at Mamallapuram is incomplete to a greater or lesser degree. But whether such a claim is persuasive or not depends on one's prior assumptions about completion. On one hand, to say that a work of South Asian sculpture or architecture is finished or not can be taken as a simple, binary opposition. It either is or is not, based on a single criterion like the artist's intention, or whether or not it has been consecrated for worship. On the other hand, if one spends much time observing the actual practices of master architects (*stapati*) and image makers (*śilpi*), both technical and ritual, the picture begins to appear far more subtle, and situation-specific. For instance, one can visit any ostensibly finished temple in Tamil Nadu and the odds will be great that a crew of *śilpi* will be seen working on some portion of it under the direction of a *stapati*.² And even where such activity is not immediately evident, one may well encounter recently executed work, or a *tiruppani* (sacred works) committee at work planning or raising funds for the continuous unfolding of the temple's (and its deities') potential for further physical manifestations. What is going on? At what point is the work finished? When have those potentials for unfoldment been completely realized? As I will argue here from an ethnographic perspective, in the light of actual practices situated within broader ritual and cultural frameworks, the question of completion turns into a subtle and complex matter, to be adequately answered in terms of *more-or-less* rather than the simple absolutes of *yes* or *no*. I will also argue that such subtleties in turn, imply larger cosmogonic and cosmological assumptions that are encoded in the rituals and techniques conditioning the making of monuments and images.

There are, of course, specific cases of incompleteness that may be due to the collapse of patronage. This general approach has been widely taken to be most practical or reasonable by scholarly disciplines operating through Western conceptions of history. And this has proven to be a productive and compelling approach that I do not wish to disparage. Rather, my aim here is to demonstrate that it is not the *only* valid way of seeing the material remnants of South Asia's pasts. And because temples and images are the physical remnants of sacrificial procedures, it behooves us to question the cosmogonic and cosmological assumptions built into Western historical conceptions, including those that entail the patron's or artist's individual intentionality, freedom of choice, or more broadly, any presumed belief in binary dualisms (*e.g.* complete versus incomplete as states of being) or purely random, idiosyncratic or accidental forces operating within a linear temporal sequence. I do not simply reject the

1 See K. R. Srinivasan, *Cave Temples of the Pallavas. vol. 1, Architectural Survey of Temples* (New Delhi: Archaeological Survey of India, 1964) for an extensive cataloguing of the monuments with explicit descriptions of the more grossly incomplete features to be seen among them.

2 *Śilpi* (*cirpi* in Tamil) and *stapati* are only loosely translatable into corresponding English terms "artisan," "artist," or "architect." The latter terms fail to convey, among other things, their ritual roles and significance.

validity of processing South Asian materials through Western presuppositions, I only hope to undermine sedimented certainties that would see it as the one and *only* rigorous, practical, disciplined, or authoritative approach to the subject.

In her article, “Unfinished Images,” Joanna Williams observes that there are in India “countless parts of temples dedicated for worship that one can hardly call anything but unfinished.”³ By “unfinished” Williams refers not to a binary opposition between consecrated or unconsecrated, but to a more sophisticated aesthetic continuum of roughness and refinement commonly seen in Indian stone carving that makes certain images appear to be incomplete when “executed in less detail than others around it.”⁴ The two shrines at Mamallapuram illustrated in figure 1 are dramatic examples of the phenomenon she is referring to.⁵ While the upper tiers are carved in significant detail, as one moves toward the bottom the natural form of the rock increasingly predominates over the carved articulation of details.⁶ On relatively more finished monuments at the site (figs. 2–3) one can still recognize a variety of surface treatments, ranging from rough to smooth, exhibiting the effects of tools that must have been very similar to those used by Tamil stone sculptors today. In the lower half of these photographs one can see the deep furrows that characterize the use of a heavy, blunt chisel that modern sculptors call *vettapu*, used for removing large chunks of stone. Such a tool is never used today for finishing work. The appearance of such tool marks on the monuments at Mamallapuram allow us to rigorously define the unfinished status of these monuments on the ethnoarchaeological grounds of local technical standards rather than the mere impressions of visitors or romantic responses to their current abandoned and ruined state. Other surfaces visible in these photographs, still rough but not quite so deeply furrowed, betray the use of a tool that must have been the ancient equivalent of what contemporary sculptors call *tēyvu*; a lighter chisel with a sharply pointed tip. This too is not a tool that is used for final finishing work. On the upper surfaces of Nandi’s body (fig. 2) one can observe smooth, flat surfaces on which no tool marks are visible. Today such a result is produced by a chisel called *palamunai*, or “many ends.” The working surface of a *palamunai* consists of a flat plane in which a series of parallel grooves have been cut at right angles (or on the diagonal) leaving many small, pointed tips that lightly pulverize the stone as the sculptor simultaneously strikes and slides it over the surface. *Palamunai* with fewer, larger tips are used for the initial smoothing, while those with more numerous and finer tips are used in later stages of the finishing process. Curved surfaces like the apsidal roof shown in figure 3, or the dome located just below the peak of the arch of the neighbouring shrine, are smoothed with a sharpened, flat chisel called *arappacam*. Today, further finishing is achieved using iron powders of varying degrees of coarseness. The highest degree of polish is often reserved for the shrine’s main

3 Joanna Williams, “Unfinished Images,” *India International Centre Quarterly* 13, no. 1 (1986), 90.

4 Williams, 102–03.

5 While it is true that what we see of these monuments today are but the fragmentary remnants of their ancient glory, it is also evident that no amount of ancient plaster and paint could have conceivably produced an impression of equalized refinements in the instances discussed here (e.g. figs. 1, 2, 3 or 4).

6 Examples such as this, located at various sites in India, show that ancient rock-cut monuments were worked from the top downward.

icon (*mūlavar*). Stone images made for more peripheral locations, especially those not destined for focussed worship, are finished with coarser iron powders or fine chisels. Evidence of the final stage of surface treatment is not visible on the ancient Mamallapuram monuments.

To a limited degree some of the variation in these surface treatments might have been obscured by plaster and paint in antiquity. However this fails to explain the extremes of this variation, nor can it account for entire sections of monuments that are left in a more-or less natural state (fig. 1) or only partially roughed out. For example consider the vague form flanked by a pair of coarsely cut pilasters on the wall of the Nakula-Sahadeva Ratha shown in figure 3. It is highly unlikely that *any* quantity of plaster and paint could have turned these highly preliminary sketches into forms equal in the refinement to some of those visible on the upper tiers of the monument. And even if one wished to speculate along those lines it would seem to necessary to beg the question of why.⁷

The juxtaposition of extremely delicate and rough-hewn surfaces on adjacent parts of the same monument is so consistent and striking that one is tempted to assume that it is the product of deliberate choices,⁸ even though there is no *explicit* sanction for such practices provided by any ancient text on architecture or sculpture, nor by any normative convention handed down pragmatically among contemporary South Indian temple architects and sculptors. A wide range of theories have been advanced during the past two hundred years to explain the unfinished appearance of monuments at Mamallapuram. N. S. Ramaswamy quotes an obscure source said to have been published in 1874 in which the Reverend Maurice Phillips, deploying ethnographic evidence extracted from the early nineteenth century MacKenzie manuscripts argued, “Not one of the temples is finished. How is this to be accounted for better than on the supposition that a great earthquake lowered the coast and extended the bed below the sea?”⁹ Today countless locals who offer their services as informal guides at Mamallapuram also routinely claim that there is a submerged city offshore due to a catastrophe that also disrupted work on the temples. The area is subject to violent storms, so it is possible that work may have been interrupted on one or more occasions for that reason. But such an explanation cannot entirely account for the unfinished character of monuments at the site, which were evidently left incomplete at various times in the seventh, eighth and in later centuries during the Vijayanagar period. Nor does it account for the same or similar qualities of incompleteness that may be observed at inland temple complexes, ancient and modern.

7 This would mean that the lower parts of each shrine would have to have been covered in very thick layers of plaster, while many of the the upper elements are carved so smoothly that a plaster coating would be almost gratuitous. This would strangely invert the customary practice today, in which if any portion of the monument is stone, it is normally the lower part (the *kalkāram*) while the thick layers of plaster are put over brick and wire armatures on the tower above.

8 Williams, 101.

9 The well known Sanskrit scholar Horace Hyman Wilson published a catalogue of this material in 1828 titled *A Descriptive Catalog of the Oriental Manuscripts and Other Articles Illustrative of the Literature, Statistics and Antiquities of the South of India; Collected by the Late Lieut Col. Colin MacKenzie, Surveyor General of India*. N. S. Ramaswamy, *2000 Years of Mamallapuram* (New Delhi: Navrang, 1989), 110. Colin MacKenzie served as Surveyor General of Madras between 1809 and 1817. He employed a large staff of local Indian researchers who, under his guidance, collected 8,076 inscriptions, 1,568 palm leaf manuscripts, 3,000 copper plates, and other assorted material.

The choice of Mamallapuram as the location of a government school of stone sculpture in the late 1950s (later expanded to focus on a broader training in temple architecture) was partly justified by another speculation, again evidently based on popular lore that still circulates in and around the village, that the monuments are unfinished because this was the site of an ancient school where young guild members were free to practice their skills without the restraining hand of a patron.¹⁰ Aside from the lack of any historical evidence to support it, this speculation requires us to imagine a method of subsistence and training radically different from the common “*guru kulam*” mode of apprenticeship described by twentieth century practitioners¹¹ or as represented in ancient texts.¹²

A prominent scholarly view of the site’s incompleteness is provided by Benjamin Rowland who, utilizing a variant of the broader interpretive frames generated by Ananda Coomaraswamy, Heinrich Zimmer and Stella Kramrisch, argued that the temples and images have been left unfinished intentionally, in order to express the perpetual emergence of form out of a formless, primal substance.¹³ This insightful line of argument has the merit of situating India’s visual representations broadly within the same conceptual milieu as philosophical perspectives preserved in texts current in South India during Pallava times, and it is quite consistent with much of the ethnographic evidence I present here. On the other hand, it poses a serious problem insofar as it presumes conventional categories of intended meanings and authorship. Speaking broadly, Williams rightly observes that “various works of art have taken on meanings that were not necessarily there in the mind of the creator.”¹⁴ Can the meanings of Indian art be reduced to a proprietary, authorial intention? Even if one ignores or dismisses the persuasive arguments of literary critics (following Roland Barthes’ announcement of the author’s death) and one replies in the affirmative, we are still left with two unfortunate options: “mere” speculation or a (likely hopeless) search for some written text in which a seventh-century author spells out

- 10 According to William Willetts, this argument was first advanced in published form by Y. Krishnan in 1961 (William Y. Willetts, *An Illustrated Annotated Annual Bibliography of Mahabalipuram on the Coromandel Coast of India, 1582–1962* [Kuala Lumpur: Department of Indian Studies, University of Malaya, 1966]), 66–67. It continues to circulate at the Government Architecture and Sculpture Training Institute at Mamallapuram as part of the local folklore about the founding of the school. See Samuel K. Parker, “Makers of Meaning: the Production of Temples and Images in South India,” (Ph. D. dissertation, University of Chicago, 1989), 65–79.
- 11 “*Guru kulam*” refers to a system in which apprentices become part of the guru’s household, and receive instruction at an actual work site. Contemporary practitioners have claimed that the idea of a separate school providing instruction in technical matters away from the temple construction site is a modern one. In the *guru kulam*, technique is not simply an academic matter to be imagined as an abstract, impersonal or independent body of knowledge. It is part of a total, personal relationship with a particular guru working on particular projects, in which an entire mode of existing as a person is transmitted from one generation to the next. See Parker, “Makers of Meaning.”
- 12 See Stella Kramrisch, “Traditions of the Indian Craftsman,” in *Traditional India: Structure and Change*, ed. Milton Singer (Philadelphia: American Folklore Society, 1959). Kramrisch’s account is consistent with the claims of living *stapatis* and *silpis* who learned through the *guru kulam* method when she observes that “from the beginning he [the Indian craftsman] shared in real work and real problems; there was no division of school from life.”
- 13 Benjamin Rowland, *Art in East and West* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1954), 122–23. Rowland effectively naturalizes and promotes this frame to a universalized status by comparison with apparently similar imagery and selected self-representations of the American sculptor John Flanagan.
- 14 Williams, 13.

“intended meanings” that conform to the expectations such terms connote in everyday English speech.¹⁵ But have not meanings already been spelled out in a sculptural language at Mamallapuram? Why would the claims of a written text be any less opaque? Are not the signs and meanings of which these monuments are composed as fully public as those of any written text? The meanings of Mamallapuram are potentially vital, but in order for them to live in the twenty-first century, the provisional death of (at least) seventh-century authors must be granted. This is not to say that authorial intention is irrelevant, but that it is not a simple or privileged determinant of significance. The author is as much a reader of the codes he or she deploys as the audience who necessarily re-authors the work in the act of reading it. Therefore, even if one has in hand a personal statement of the author’s subjective intentions, such claims must be understood to be self-representations: objectified and verbalized “intentions” which provide further data *for* explanation, but they are not totally adequate in themselves *as* sole explanation.

Padma Kaimal has developed a lively and insightful framework for understanding the diverse interpretive strategies that may have been utilized by the seventh-century audience to which the large relief at Mamallapuram was addressed.¹⁶ Through the lenses of “playful ambiguities,” poetic resonances (*dvani*), and built-in accommodations for multiply layered readings by diverse viewers, the unfinished character of the relief reinforces the open-endedness of the interpretive process, seemingly presupposed by the makers of the composition.¹⁷ However, even Kaimal’s interpretation of seventh-century authors and audiences belongs to the end of the twentieth century. It is an effective and persuasive example of how living people can gain sympathetic insight into seventh-century perspectives while not pretending to literally be a seventh-century perspective. The “lives of Indian images” did not end in antiquity.¹⁸

15 Roland Barthes’ landmark essay, “The Death of the Author,” (*Image, Music, Text*, ed. and trans. Stephen Heath [New York: Hill, 1977]), challenges the presupposition that the “author” is the unproblematic origin (and thus private property-owner) of the text, and shatters the simple belief that any valid reading, or “correct” interpretation, consists of establishing the author’s original intention. For Barthes it is language (and specifically writing) that creates the “author.” The text, as a child of *language*, is necessarily public and intersubjective. It is not reducible to individualistic or subjective intentions. For Barthes, “the text is a tissue of quotations drawn from innumerable centers of culture,” hence, the author (or the scholar speaking on behalf of a dead author’s biography and supposed intention) can never claim any final authority over the text. Constituted as it is of a complex field of shared, public signs, the text’s significance can never be properly reduced to subjective intention, but must always remain an *intersubjective* phenomenon. In Barthes’ model, the text thereby opens up into an indefinite, plurality of readings. However they do not become infinite or absolutely relativistic. Language and history remain substantial constraints, supporting a limited range of potentially valid readings. Barthes’ argument does emphatically *not* support an oxymoronic form of absolute egalitarian relativism that might claim that all readings are subjective and therefore none any better or worse than any others.

16 Padma Kaimal, “Playful Ambiguity and Political Authority in the Large Relief at Mamallapuram,” *Ars Orientalis* 24, (1994), 1–27.

17 Kaimal, 21.

18 Richard H. Davis, *The Lives of Indian Images* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1997).

The dominant framework of twentieth-century research at Mamallapuram has encouraged explanations of unfinished projects, either explicitly or indirectly, with reference to the careers of kings. This perspective almost inevitably follows from a rigorously narrow, text-based approach centered on naturalized presuppositions about (royal) authorship and (linear/quantified) chronology in the history of art.¹⁹ For example, on the basis of inscriptional evidence Ernest Hultzsch speculated in 1910 that the site was left unfinished due to the sudden defeat of the Pallavas by the Chalukya king Vikramāditya II (reigned 733–46).²⁰ Joanna Williams notes a serious contradiction between the narrow, ad hoc character of such specific historical explanations and the far more *general* character of the phenomenon they supposedly explain:

In India we may search first for general explanations, since this polarity of roughness and refinement is so widespread. After that, one may also look for the particular accident that interrupted the carving; or the particular iconological significance that justifies a rough image.²¹

While scholars of ancient Indian art have habitually sought answers in written texts, Williams proposes an expanded approach that includes careful observations of actual *practices*, as evidenced by material traces produced in antiquity and/or in the living practices of contemporary patrons and image makers. Such observations tend to undermine speculations about incomplete projects based primarily on the death of the artist or the patron. They do provide evidence that at least in some cases technical difficulties can encourage the abrupt abandonment of a project. More generally, however, she recognizes the phenomenon of unfinished images to be broadly grounded in philosophy, taste, and social organization.²²

The practices and aesthetic orientations of contemporary South Indian temple builders, image makers, and their patrons (the *yajamāna* or *karttā*) can shed significant light on the question of apparently incomplete images, however, they will not provide anything like a final or exhaustive answer. Indeed, in part I hope to further undermine the reader's faith (if any) in such absolutely definitive answers; to enrich, even aggravate, the dialogue, not extinguish it with the stamp of final authority or exhaustive and irrefutable facts.

19 See Gabriel Jouveau-Dubreuil, *Pallava Antiquities* (London: Probsthain, 1916–18); Albert H. Longhurst, *Pallava Architecture* (3 parts) *Memoirs of the Archaeological Survey of India* 17, 30 and 40. (Simla, 123 and Calcutta, 1928 and 1930: Archaeological Survey of India, 1923–1930); R. Nagaswamy, "New Light on Mahabalipuram," *Transactions of the Archaeological Society of South India: 1960–62* (Madras: Archaeological Society of South India, 1962), 1–50; Michael Lockwood, Gift Siromoney and P. Dayanandan, *Mahabalipuram Studies* (Madras: Christian Literature Society, 1974).

20 Ramaswamy, 1989, 137.

21 Williams, 105.

22 Williams, 105.

A useful line of approach to the question of incomplete monuments appears to be suggested by E. Valentine Daniel's ethnographic study of modern Tamil house construction in which builders claim to observe a formalized "rule of incompleteness."

According to the "rule of incompleteness," no stage should be completed before the next stage begins. Thus, when the foundation is laid, at least one little stone in some corner should be allowed to remain loose or improperly placed until the construction of the wall begins, after which the builder may return to make snug and cement the loose stone and perfect the foundation... Finally, when the roof is constructed, it is made of an odd number of beams, odd numbers being considered incomplete. Thus, the house as a whole remains an "incomplete structure."²³

Srinivasan incidentally describes a logically similar sequence in his reconstruction of the stages of the carving of the Dharmarāja Ratha at Mamallapuram (fig. 4), in which subsequent stages of the work were clearly undertaken while previous stages were left in the incomplete states we see them today.²⁴ Although he is ultimately developing an argument about chronology and authorship, he does so by carefully considering the production process, comparing the traces of ancient practices with his observations of contemporary Tamil stone carvers.²⁵ He analyses the temple in three spatiotemporal stages: a nearly completed *uparitala* (top tier) a less complete *madhyatala* (middle tier) and a markedly incomplete *āditala* (lower tier). He uses a variety of ad hoc explanations to account for the range of finish exhibited by specific portions of the structure. Unfinished parts of the top tier are partly explained by the difficulty of working in the tight spaces of the upper galleries.²⁶ A flaw in the stone discovered while excavating the base (*adhiṣṭhāna*) of the monument contributes a reason for the unfinished foundation.²⁷ And, he speculates, that there must have been a sudden (military or political?) interruption of the project just as the middle tier was nearing completion,²⁸ and when work was resumed at a later date, the lower tier (*āditala*) was undertaken hurriedly, without regard for completing unfinished work on the upper tiers.²⁹ Quite apart from these contingent reasons, the sequence Srinivasan describes also faithfully adheres to the house builder's "rule of incompleteness." Were the codes followed by ancient temple architects in Tamil Nadu closer to those of house builders than they are today?

Several factors undermine the adequacy of an explicit "rule of incompleteness" as an explanation for temples and their imagery. If such an explicit and seemingly important rule existed among ancient

23 E. Valentine Daniel, *Fluid Signs: Being a Person the Tamil Way* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1984), 131.

24 K. R. Srinivasan, *The Dharmaraja Ratha and its Sculptures* (New Delhi: Abhinav, 1975).

25 Based primarily on stylistic and technical evidence Srinivasan (87–89) exposes the flaws of controversial claims regarding the date and patronage of the monument that have been made on the basis of narrowly defined and, in his view, over-interpreted, inscriptions on stone made by R. Nagaswamy, (*New Light on Mahabalipuram* [Madras: Archaeological Society of South India, Silver Jubilee Volume, 1962], 1–50), and on copper plates made by N. Ramesan, (*New Light on the Shore Temple* [Hyderabad: Government of Andhra Pradesh Archaeological Series No. 29, 1972]).

26 Srinivasan, 60–61.

27 Srinivasan, 50.

28 Srinivasan, 52–55.

29 Srinivasan, 51.

temple builders it is strange that there is no mention of it in any of the *purāṇas*, *āgamas* or *śilpāśāstras* that treat temple architecture as a rule-governed practice. If it was perpetuated in the oral versions of *śāstra* that continue to be transmitted from one generation of practitioners to the next one might hope to find some trace of sympathy for such a rule among modern *stapatis*. However, in the course of my research, contemporary *stapatis* universally and unequivocally denied that the house builder's rule of incompleteness applies to temples or their images. While incompleteness serves as one among several blemishes (such as ugly demon masks, painted pumpkins or scarecrows) that are intended to protect the householder's property from the evil eye, temples and gods, they insist, are far too powerful to be vulnerable to human envy or greed and thus, they do not require such devices. Nevertheless, whenever I directed their attention to the evidence all around them, *stapatis* readily admitted to me that no temple is ever really completed in Tamil Nadu. A temple becomes ritually, or ideologically complete when it is consecrated even though much physical work remains to be done. There are always the demands of unfinished business – gateways (*gōṭṭurams*), halls (*maṇḍapams*), surrounding walls (*prākārams*), subsidiary shrines, renovations, and so on – at every temple complex. The completion of an image is similarly indefinite. A sculptor once explained to me that there is virtually no end to the refinements that are possible to lavish upon a statue; it will be as rough and simple, or as refined and ornamented as the donor is willing or able to afford. If the donor is (or is perceived to be) stingy, the carver's efforts will likely be correspondingly attenuated, resulting in a less-finished appearance.

One *stapati* argued that a temple *might* be finished if enough money were to ever be made available, but because India is a poor country the work cannot be done all at once. In contrast, another noted that it is precisely the wealthiest temples, like those at Tirupati or Srirangam, that always have the most unfinished work. They are the ones that can afford to be perpetually in pursuit of ongoing, ambitious programs for indefinite expansion. In particular, the Śrī Venkateswara temple at Tirupati supports a full time *stapati* for architecture and another for wood who oversee a substantial work force of draftsmen, supervisors (*nūl pōṭṭupavar* or *sūtragrahin*), skilled *śilpis* and common laborers whose numbers fluctuate depending on the intensity of the expansion projects underway at any given time.

And yet even if a temple were to be totally “completed,” such a status would still be necessarily provisional. According to popular oral versions of *śāstric* knowledge, the temple is supposed to be renovated on a schedule following the twelve year cycle of Guru (Jupiter, an expansive, auspicious planet), at which time not only must it be physically refreshed and reconsecrated, but also improvements and additions to the complex should be undertaken.

The incompleteness of temples and images cannot, therefore simply be explained with reference to a single explicit rule like the house builder's rule of incompleteness. It is not the product of a hidebound, unthinking adherence to *śāstra* or the rules of a reified “tradition.” Rather the procedures for making both houses and temples are embedded in a more fundamental, and implicit, framework of normative, and sometimes formally ritualized, practices which are shaped through shared presuppositions about the perpetually unfolding (or oscillating)³⁰ nature of the real world we live and work in.

30 Richard H. Davis, *Ritual in an Oscillating Universe: Worshipping Siva in Medieval India* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1991).



Fig. 1 Pidari Rathas. Mamallapuram. 7th century A.D. Photograph by the author.



Fig. 2. Nandi. Mamallapuram.
7th century A.D.
Photograph by Prithwish Neogy.



Fig. 3. Nakula Sahadeva Ratha. Mamallapuram. 7th century A.D. Photograph by Prithwish Neogy.

Fig. 4. Dharmarāja Ratha. Mamallapuram.
7th century A.D.
Photograph by Prithwish Neogy.

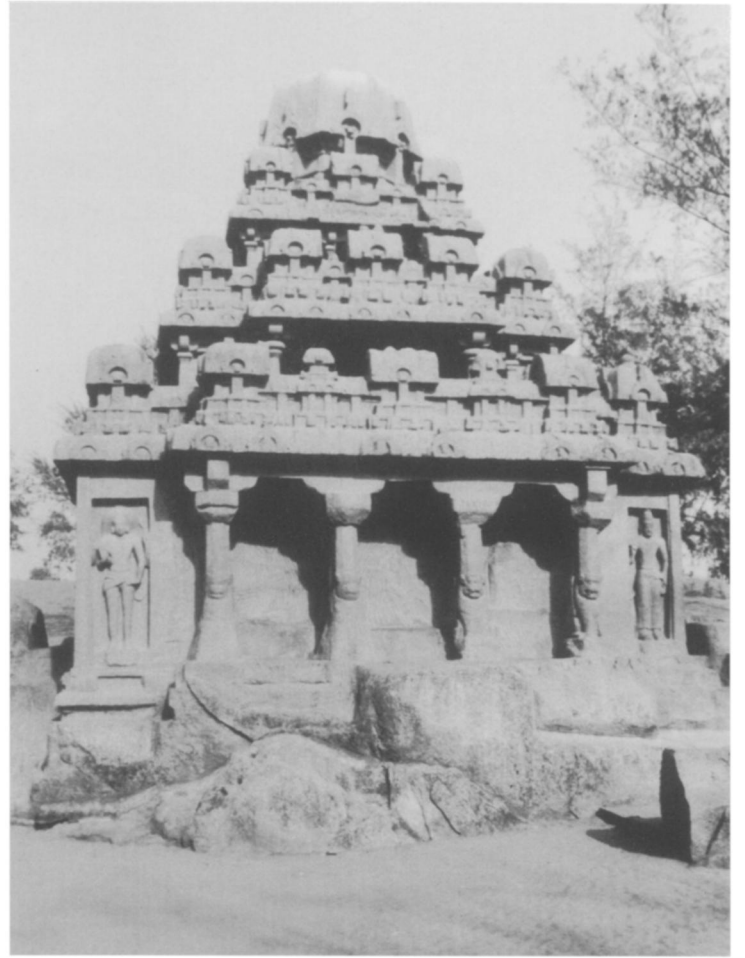


Fig. 5. Mahiṣāsuramardinī relief. Mamallapuram. 7th century A.D. Photograph by Prithwish Neogy.



Fig. 6. Large relief. Mamallapuram. 7th century A.D. Photograph by Prithwish Neogy.

SELF-CONSTRUCTION:
SACRED WORKS (TIRUPPAṆI) AND PATRONS (KARTTA)

The formal pattern of donation for sacred works (*tiruppaṇi*) replicates the incomplete properties of the temple complex and provides further insight into its tacit rationale. Donations for temple projects are ritually offered in amounts that follow the conventional formula of an even number plus one (e.g. Rs 51, Rs 101, or Rs 1001). When asked about this practice most donors report simply that such numbers are “auspicious.” On a few rare occasions I was told such amounts are given so that the project can “grow,” or that it means that “the giving will continue.” One *stapati* noted that the extra rupee is like a “seed” that primes the next round of giving. *Tiruppaṇi* collections thus follow the general pattern described by Daniel:

Among Tamils, as among most South Asians, a gift of cash is generally given in an odd numbered sum... the message behind the gift is “this is but a faulty gift, an *incomplete* one; kindly accept it.” In acknowledging its blemish and *incompleteness*, the giver, rather than saying, “this is it,” says, “there is more to come” (*italics added*).³¹

The chief donor of a temple project is called *karttā* (doer) in Tamil and *yajamāna* (sacrificer) in Sanskrit. Both terms are in common use in Tamil Nadu. The ritual of temple construction is a formally structured – and hence controllable – sort of doing, explicitly designed to generate beneficial effects. As the Tamil expression *vinay yaccam* (residue of action) indicates, the moral qualities of an act are commonly presumed to leave something like a physical residue, or trace, on the actor’s person. Such traces are not static. They are fertile potentials that can be described in the popular agricultural metaphors of everyday South Indian talk as a “seed,” that will grow and bear fruit, sweet or sour, depending on the quality of the original act. The acts that are commonly claimed to produce the most desirable residues (and, in the course of time, fruits) are those of giving (*tānam*, or *dāna* in Sanskrit). Indeed, the giving of *tānam* is widely said to be the supreme *dharmā* (moral duty) of the Kali Yuga (the present cosmic cycle).

Among the first steps in the making of a modern temple or image is the calculation of *āyāti*.³² Ganapati Stapati analyzes the etymology of *āyāti* as the “origin of benefit”³³ for the donor.³⁴ Technically it is the remainder of a calculation designed to determine the auspicious number of units for the overall size of a temple or image. Its aim is an optimal *match* of the deity and temple site with the specific pattern of qualities, or past preparations (*saṃskāras*), embodied in the donor, as astrologically and/or numerologically diagnosed. Ganapati Stapati compares *āyāti* to match-making in marriage: “just as we seek longevity and offspring in making a marriage, we should seek fulfilment of our intention [in

³¹ Daniel, 134.

³² Ganapati Stapati, *Cirpa Cennūl*, (Madras: Tolil Nūtpak kalvi Iyakkam, 1978), 25–31.

³³ Ganapati Stapati, 26.

³⁴ Ganapati Stapati derives the word *āyāti* from Tamil, however the Sanskrit *āyāti* is glossed as “coming near, arrival” (Sir M. Monier-Williams, *A Sanskrit-English Dictionary* [Oxford, U.K.: Oxford University Press, 1899], 149), which would suggest the “coming-together” of donor, deity, and site, the three basic elements of *āyāti* calculations.

image and temple making] by using *āyāti*.”³⁵ Thus, the shaping and functioning of the temple simultaneously shapes the unfolding destiny of the donor.

Whatever else it may be, temple construction should be also understood as a particularly potent instrument for self construction. Both self and the cosmos are treated as patterned processes objectifying themselves in and through coarse matter. Those patterns are ritually and technically realized in the analysis of astrological signs – in a broad sense that can include physiognomy, lines on the palm, the length or width of a donor’s finger (*aṅgula*), or the numerological analysis of names (*nāma nakṣatra*) – combined with *āyāti*, systems of proportions and iconographic forms. These activities presume that both the self and the world are materially unfolding in specifically patterned ways, shaped by the qualitative properties of objectifying actions. Thus, the temple/image mediates self and world, and harmonizes them through an act of re-marking – or equally describable as re-making – in order to bring about auspicious consequences: children, prosperity, dignity, wisdom, liberation: in short, successes in all things gross and subtle, immediate and ultimate. This of course is not exactly how either a *stapati* or a *yajamāna* is likely to put it. The somewhat complex language I have used here is intended to draw out and expose implicit, taken-for-granted assumptions that are evidently built into the ritualized ordering of largely *non-verbal* temple construction practices. Verbal practices – explicit local talk about temples and patronage – are data of another sort.

AN AESTHETIC OF INCOMPLETION?

The simultaneous appearance of virtually the entire range of tool treatments on the monuments at Mamallapuram, from the deep furrows of blunt roughing-in tools to the delicate refinements of surface and shape produced by fine, finishing chisels, visible on adjacent parts of the same monument generate a dynamic sense of form, not only as a product, but as deictic signifiers of the process of their production. A continuum of indexical traces in the stone mask human labor at the most fully differentiated extreme of their refinements and clearly expose it at the other extreme. Consequently these signifying traces are able to function simultaneously as both aesthetic signifier and conceptual signified.

One problem with this line of interpretation however, is its lack of ancient written textual support. It is also alien to contemporary stone sculptors who consider the appearance of tool marks to be an aesthetic defect: an indicative sign that the sculptor gave up too soon (which is to say, once again, that from a local, technical perspective the work has been left “incomplete”). The finishing techniques used on the surfaces of contemporary stone sculpture indicate that a fully realized piece should be smooth, tactile, like the skin of a mango. It should look as if it could have grown into its present shape from the inside out.³⁶ This contemporary preference seems to implicitly articulate an aesthetic of

35 Ganapati Stapati, 25.

36 Modern sculptors generally only leave the surface relatively rough in response to extremely cost-conscious patrons who refuse to provide adequate compensation for their labor. See Samuel K. Parker, “The Matter of Value Inside and Out: Aesthetic Categories in Contemporary Hindu Temple Arts,” *Ars Orientalis* 22, (1992), 97.

svayambhu (self-born) imagery. Which is to say that a fine sculpture should seem to have grown into its present shape as if on its own. Tool marks accentuate the status of the object as a product of human fabrication. Their elimination not only produces a continuous, sensuously smooth surface, it allows the viewer to favorably assess carved forms in relation to naturally, or self-manifesting images that set the standards of divine potency and beauty. To the extent that sculptors today speak of their profession as *dharmā*, a sacred calling, or duty, they commonly refer to themselves as instruments through which divine power and received wisdom are made manifest in temples and their imagery. Even if the form is obviously realized through human agency, in truth it embodies the will and manifesting power of the divinity whose body (or *kōyil*, “palace”) the sculptor is shaping.

How can one reconcile the evidence of our senses, which respond to the deictic traces of what ancient stone carvers actually did, with the silence of ancient texts and the ostensible disapproval of contemporary practitioners? One line of approach would be to situate the visible, rough-refined continuum in relation to other evident distinctions, explicit and implied, that can mutually help articulate a general perspective through which incompleteness, and a number of other, similar phenomena, fit together as aspects of a larger, more or less coherent, picture. I will consider two such sets of distinction here. A specific case of ancient compositional order and a general case of modern systems of proportion.

The Durgā Maḥiṣāsura-mardīnī relief at Mamallapuram (fig. 5) justifies its status as a masterpiece of Indian sculpture not by its novelty, but in part by the manner in which it effectively realizes the compositional type of which it is a specific example. The field of battle is represented here as an elliptical space, delimited by the group of heavy masculine warriors on the viewer’s right, opposed to a group of playful dwarves on the left. These groupings respectively encircle the two primary protagonists, the goddess Durgā and the Buffalo Demon Maḥiṣa. The spherical head of a falling warrior, who seems as if he is being pulled out of the background by a female agent of the goddess, provides a central hub unifying the two opposing groups into one overall composition. The structure of the entire composition is replicated at the level of its two primary constituent parts. On the viewer’s left the goddess Durgā sits astride her lion. While she is fully human, distinct from the beast she rides, the demonic nature of her opponent is suggested by a fusion of human and beastly forms. She seems to rise, and float, as if qualitatively answering the gravitational, downward pull implied by the buffalo demon’s falling posture. Her confident advance is echoed by his defensive gestures of retreat and defeat, anticipated by the collapsing warriors located in front of him.

Nevertheless, the two are both honored with parasols above their heads, and unified by the substantive mass of stone from which they both seem to swell forth; a primordial ground of unshaped matter, ultimate mother of all differentiated form.³⁷ The dynamism of the composition can be likened to a fluid in motion. Like the relation of wave and trough, these opposed forces are distinct, yet also the unified products of a single cosmic surge.

37 N. Ray, *Idea and Image in Indian Art* (New Delhi: Mushiram Manoharlal, 1973), 55–88.

On one hand, the beauty of the goddess is constituted by contrast to the bulky and coarse body of the buffalo demon. Her beauty is asserted, not as a positive essence, but as a *relational difference*. Her body fully realizes its potential for separation from its animal qualities. The animal aspect of her being now *serves* her as a powerful vehicle, it does not *drive* her through an identification with its demonic appetites (Mahiṣa on the other hand, is visually and narratively fused with the *tamasic*, animal appetites of his being, thereby becoming a virtually insatiable demon that only Durgā can overcome).

On the other hand, the beauty of her body is also asserted by its juxtaposition to the stunted, undeveloped human proportions of the *gaṇas* (divine dwarves) who playfully surround her. This contrast is central to the definition of her relative beauty when read through language of contemporary image makers. For them, the relative values of bodily proportions are codified in the form of a visual grammar called the *tālamāna* system. *Tāla* refers to the stages, or units, used in the proportional design of an image (or the number of stories to be used for a given building). The *tālamāna* system consists of a range of positional values that implicitly “move” from one to ten tiers. According to Ganapati Sthapati’s textbook *Cirpacennūl*, one tier is used for such imagery as an egg (*mutṭai* or *aṇḍa*), or Viṣṇu’s turtle avatar. Two tiers are used for Viṣṇu’s fish avatar, three tiers for *kinnaras* (celestial bird-human composites), four tiers for children, five tiers are prescribed for Viṣṇu’s dwarf incarnation, and Gaṇeśa, lord of the *gaṇas*. Six is specified for representing short people, seven for the monkey god Hanuman, eight tiers for human beings, nine for celestial musicians, adepts, demons and directional deities, and finally ten tiers is reserved for the highest gods and goddesses (see illustrations in *Cirpacennūl*, 191–289). Each of the nine- and ten-tier categories are further subdivided into lower (*atama*), middle (*mattima*) and upper (*uttama*).³⁸ Altogether the system encodes a developmental chain of being, ranging from an egg, or turtle form, through lower animals, children, dwarves, humans, and a wide array of ranked divinities. Bodily proportion thereby serves a code through which a process of formal, developmental realization, something like the unfolding of a lotus, can be deployed in visual compositions to mark the relational values of diverse components.

If considered in this light, the ancient polarization of rough and refined surfaces may be understood to replicate the same logic of progressive, formal realization in another register: the indexical trace of the sculptor’s labor. As such it need not have ever functioned through obedience to explicit rules, nor need it have been made inevitable or determined by an explicitly formulated ideology. It is rather one among many ways through which a generalized cosmogonic understanding might be transformed into structures of creative practice, yielding the material, deictic traces of “incompletion” we observe in the ancient monuments at Mamallapuram. Technical incompleteness however, does seem to have an advantage over alternative signifying strategies in that it can potentially evoke an immediacy and implication of aliveness, as if the object is still forming, moving, growing, breathing...

38 There are a number of divine-child icons represented by five tiers, hence it is also subdivided into lower middle and upper categories. On the other hand, relatively few images are represented using one, two, three, four, six, seven, or eight tiers, and so they are not routinely subdivided this way even though in theory they could be.

THE SHAPING OF MATTER AS RITUAL

When viewed from a slightly different angle, the physical processes by which architects and image makers shape gross matter into temples and icons can also be understood as an extended act of sacrifice. In South India sacrificing is practiced as a creative act in which substances are transformed through a kind of miniature *pralaya* (cosmic dissolution, or death, typically mediated by fire, water or dismemberment) that, like sex (or death and decay) yields a fertile leftover, a “seed,” from which renewal occurs. Here the creative process is treated as a kind of re-creation, or rebirth. The residues of sacrificial transformations, such as sacred ash (*vibhūti*), blessed objects and eatables (*prasād*), a building site (*vāstu*), temple (*prāsāda*), or an icon (*vigraha*), is invested with special, generative power through this process.

Ancient written texts explicitly represent temple construction as an ongoing process of growth. According to the *Ajitāgama*, the temple should be able to grow like a plant.³⁹ The *Tantra Samuccaya* identifies five stages in the life of a building: infancy, boyhood, manhood, old age, and death.⁴⁰ In a similar vein, I was once informed that Śiva should ideally awaken each morning to the ringing sound of chisels, again indicating the idea that the temple is an unending structure-in-process.⁴¹ However, another *stapati* said that whoever told me that must have thought the idea would be good for business. The overall size of the temple or image, as determined by *āyāti* calculations, is established by drawing a *madhya sūtra*, or central line, which is something like a cosmic axis in miniature. As a stone image is carved the *madhya sūtra* is repeatedly drawn and re-drawn, in red ochre or charcoal, as the central referent around which the icon develops. The *madhya sūtra* itself is theoretically reducible even further to a singular point (*bindu*), of which it is a linear extension. While the center of a sanctum or the navel of an icon may be identified as such a singular point, practically speaking it is the *madhya sūtra* that serves as the generative center for a temple or an image. It is the line, not the point, that can be numerologically customized to match the qualitative properties of the donor, deity and site. The unity of the center line is then metaphorically “sacrificed” by dividing it into a rhythmic series of formalized proportions that mark the locations of body parts or, for what amounts to virtually the same thing, the components of the temple complex (which are also partially described in Tamil using the names of human body parts). Thus the making proceeds from the whole to the part by an act of differentiation, much as the cosmic code man, Purusa, is sacrificially divided to yield an ordered universe.

The differentiated *madhya sūtra* provides the underlying pattern for integrating every subordinate element of a temple or an image into a potent and harmonious whole. Large architectural or sculptural compositions are thereby hierarchically organized with reference to their centers (and hence from there

39 Bruno Dagens, *Architecture in the Ajitāgama and the Rauravāgama: A Study of Two South Indian Texts* (New Delhi: Sitaram Bhartia Institute of Scientific Research, 1984), 30.

40 N. V. Mallayya, *Studies in Sanskrit Temple Architecture with Special Reference to the Tantra Samuccaya* (Chidambaram: Annamalai University, n.d.), 131.

41 Contemporary stone carvers routinely assess the relative merits of stones by the sound they make when struck by a chisel. The best stone is that with the most musical ring. This practice appears to be most explicitly codified in the musical pillars commonly made for South Indian temples during the last half millennium.

to their donors). The large relief at Mamallapuram (fig. 6) may be taken as an example of this ordering practice. The imagery is distributed around what is probably a natural cleft in the rock: a *svayambhu* (self-born) *madhya sūtra*.⁴² Beings of all sorts, human, animal and divine, are distributed around the center line like a halo, roughly elliptical in shape. They are generally portrayed in postures oriented as if they are being defined and drawn by the magnetic power of the center. Among these peripheral forms there are a number of subsidiary centers that anchor smaller elliptical clusters of beings. For instance, a group of forest dwelling animals and holy men and on the lower (proper) right revolves around a gravitational center marked by an *ekatāla* (one tier) Nārāyaṇa shrine. Just above them another group surrounds Śiva and an ascetic, while on the opposite side of the cleft a group of mice encircle a cat who displays a posture echoing that of the ascetic. Likewise, other subordinated groups consisting of animal families and flying couples reveal a compositional pattern in which larger groups are composed of smaller groups replicating the centrally organized pattern of the entire field. If one adopts an even more localized focus, the volumes of each body can be seen as harmoniously distributed around an implied *madhya sūtra* – often coincident with the spine, upholding axis of the body, or around which the spine snakes, as in the case of flexed postures – that was probably used in the design and carving process.⁴³

Such a composition is analogous to an indefinitely expanding system of galaxies and galaxy clusters, each level of grouping organized in relation to a hierarchy of centers. This composition is not defined by its limits – a geometrical frame – as say, a Renaissance painting is. Its outer limits are provisional and pragmatic, not abstract or constitutional. The large relief at Mamallapuram could have been enlarged ever further with the addition of more subordinated groups. Indeed, on the lower right is a relatively untouched field of stone, marked only by some rough cuts that seem to function

42 Walter Smith persuasively argues that the sculptural articulations of the landscape at Mamallapuram serve to heighten the viewer's awareness of divine powers already embodied in the site's natural features. See "The Viṣṇu Image in the Shore Temple at Māmallapuram," *Artibus Asiae* 56, nos. 1/2 (1996), 20. Focussing on the rock-cut image of the Sleeping Viṣṇu in the Shore Temple, Smith suggests that a natural horizontal outcropping of stone periodically bathed by the tides provided a dramatic natural metaphor of Viṣṇu's worship in his primordial environment (21). During Pallava times the stone was carved to reveal its iconographic features with clarity and a temple was constructed around it.

43 Michael D. Rabe integrates material and textual evidence to plausibly speculate on the original intention of the apparent patron of this relief, Mahamalla Narasimhavarman I (reigned 630–68) and perhaps less plausibly, speculates that the seventh-century Tamil Poet Daṇḍin's references to a mid-century artist named Māndhātara was head of the atelier responsible for the carving. See "The Māmallapuram Praśati: A Panegyric in Figures," *Artibus Asiae* 57, nos. 3/4 (1997), 189–242. Rabe's contextualizing approach, associating connections among elements within the relief to human circumstances and purposes outside of it, is a sound one within its limits. Such an analysis can confidently indicate the type of meaningful associations encoded in the relief, but it cannot exhaust them or specify ancient authorial intentions with any precision. If Rabe's sophisticated reading is taken as simply right or wrong, without an appropriate degree of humility, or if it is used to support a common-sense theory of meaning in which the only correct interpretation is presumed to be the exclusive (private) property of a seventh-century author's subjective intention, it would only be fair to admit that these are dimensions of a fairly recent frame of reference most clearly articulated in eighteenth-century voices of the European and American enlightenment and may have little or no relation to ancient Indian ways of seeing things.

as a kind of visual *etcetera*. One can almost imagine the sculptors to be on break, fully intending to return to the project soon. This composition is indefinite, open-ended and therefore perpetually incomplete by organizational *structure*, quite independent of any possible royal accidents that may or may not have interrupted the work.

Any large temple complex in Tamil Nadu could be used to illustrate how the same organizing practices operate in architectural aesthetics. Tamil temples grow outward over the centuries, successively enveloping their centers with the addition of small shrines for ritually subordinated deities, *maṇḍapams* for elaborated ritual functions and, perhaps most prominently, with the proliferation of concentric compound walls interrupted by gateways located either along the axis of the deity's gaze (*pārvai*), or toward the four cardinal points of the compass.

There is always leftover, unfinished architectural business following any round of construction activity. Temporally, the same creative logic that locates generative power in the remnant of the sacrifice is also expressed in the indefinitely incomplete structure of temple complexes that continue to grow, decay, be renewed, and grow again, from one generation to the next. The oscillating pressures to elaborate, renovate and expand existing temple complexes come from their social environments. Once a given phase of a construction is more or less completed, at least to the extent that the temple can be (re)consecrated and used, this pressure is usually at its nadir, drained along with the financial resources of the temple's supporters. Later, architectural asymmetries, unfinished foundations, improprieties, evident violations of *śāstra*, improvements on neighboring temples, the fading of paint and the crumbling of mortar, all or in part may combine to build public demand for another cycle of additions and renovations.

The remnants of the sacrifice (ashes, leftover foods and liquids) are the empowered, creative seeds of further developments. In the rituals of South Indian Temple construction excess – or incomplete – production can be understood as remnants following the same model. The remnants of architectural rites typically include the unfinished bases of enormous gateways (*gōṇpurams*) that are seen at many major temple complexes in Tamil Nadu. These were mostly begun by ancient kings who seemingly bequeathed them to future generations as a challenge, to keep the temple (and the kingdom) dynamic and expanding. Although those kingdoms have long since faded, variants of the same cosmogonic assumptions that animated them are also embedded in the common-sense of many contemporary Tamils. Hence the architectural challenges of ancient kings are addressed today by modern coalitions of holy men, industrialists, politicians, entertainers, merchants and an untold host of small scale donors.⁴⁴

We may now return to the initial question: why do the monuments at Mamallapuram seem to display varying degrees of completion? Specific cases may have something to do with the death or defeats of patrons, flaws in the stone, or other such technical difficulties. However, a more fundamental answer can be offered in two closely related observations. First, the concept of completion itself, in ordinary English usage, entails finishing, or putting an *end* to something, and thus, the question itself

44 Samuel K. Parker, "Contemporary Temple Construction in South India: The Srirangam Rajagopuram," *Res* 21, (1992), 110–23.

is intriguingly misplaced. Second, in *addition* to the remarks that Williams and others have made about unfinished images in South Asia, I would include the observation that they display varying degrees of finish partly because they are the remnants of sacrificial processes.

THE OBJECTS OF STUDY FOR AN INDIAN ART HISTORY

A sustained examination of unfinished images in India eventually leads us to question the ontological status of the objects being examined.⁴⁵ What sort of entities are they? Scholarly answers cannot hope to reproduce anything like “native points of view.” Such points of view have already been provided anyway in abundance by ancient and modern Hindu commentators. By contrast, the sort of scholarly knowledge of Hindu imagery generated through modern academic disciplines is necessarily dialogical, and therefore the categories of observation are (or where they are not, should become) questioned as they are invoked.

In the nineteenth century Hindu images were often negatively characterized as “idols” or “fetishes.”⁴⁶ The terms “*arcā*,” or “*vigraham*” (*vikkirakam*) are today sometimes loosely translated as “idol,” but they do not carry the negative semantic load of idolatry, fetishism, excessive, or misplaced value associated with the word “idol” in English. In the twentieth century more sympathetic observers have participated in their positive re-valorization as “art” objects. These categories, idol and art object, may not be as distinct as they initially appear.

The idea of “Hindu idolatry” can also be interpreted as an ethnocentric displacement of demons frequently exercised, and exorcized, by the so-called Peoples of the Book – Jews, Christians and Muslims – who claim a common heritage in the Old Testament and share a complicated, sometimes troubled history of responses to graven images. For example, as Davis⁴⁷ and others⁴⁸ have amply shown, evidence of Muslim iconoclasm in India was historically complex, intermittent and subject to alternative readings. However, at certain historical junctures, local practices, reified by non-participating observers as a unitary something called “Hinduism,” apparently functioned as a convenient repository for a demonizing concept of idolatry, thereby symbolically (but ultimately ineffectively) purifying those observers of their own deeply ingrained cultural predispositions. After all, the People of the Book could be arguably described as the world’s pre-eminent fetishists. Their historical struggles over idolatry tended to focus, not on fetishism *per se*, but on the politically acceptable *form* of the fetish. Graven

45 The term status is probably too static for an adequate statement of the question, and yet a term like “dynamics” misses the mark too.

46 The terms *arcā* or *vigraham* are commonly translated by the English term “idol” even though the overlap in significance is far from perfect. In particular, the South Asian terms conspicuously lack the negative associations commonly carried by the terms “idol,” or “fetish.”

47 Davis, *The Lives of Indian Images*, 88–112.

48 Barbara D. Metcalf, “Presidential Address: Too Little and Too Much: Reflections on Muslims in the History of India,” *Journal of Asian Studies* 54, no. 4 (1995), 951–67.

words were commonly promoted at the expense of graven images.⁴⁹ Therefore it seems to have been almost irresistibly appealing for some outsiders to paint the “Hinduism” of their own imagination with the broad brush of idolatry. In one stroke the Hindus could be made knowable, ostensibly distant, yet implicitly near to the iconoclast’s heart.

By contrast, in practice it is not the idol in itself that is the focus of so-called Hindu idolatry, but the living presence of the deity that has been ritually invited to reside in the temple and its images. Temple construction and image making allow humans to establish relationships of hospitality, patronage and gratitude with invisible beings, who are otherwise too subtle for our coarse modes of everyday behavior and awareness. When it is abandoned by the deity, the material form of a Hindu icon is liable to be publicly treated as an inauspicious corpse, something to be disposed of or avoided. Possibly the most obvious expression of such non-fetishizing attitudes among Hindu worshippers is the ritual destruction of images that occurs at the conclusion of the festivals for which they are repeatedly made (and remade). But even durable images in stone, mortar or bronze are liable to be seen negatively if they have not been receiving worship, or if some act of defilement has provoked the departure of the deity: abandoned temples are commonly identified by Tamil villagers as the residence of snakes, ghosts, demons, thieves and other undesirables, and the accidental unearthing of a neglected icon is as likely to be taken as an inauspicious occasion requiring its proper disposal, commonly by immersion in a body of water, as it is to be interpreted as an auspicious occurrence requiring the re-invocation of the divine presence through proper rites.

The image making practices described above further suggest that Hindu temples and icons are also misrecognized when seen through the classificatory frame of “art.” The development of the art concept in Europe can be at least partially interpreted as the product of a historical transformation in which the religious “idol” is rescued, purified by its abstraction from concrete contexts, and positively re-valued as a secular, aesthetic fetish. These acts have been widely rationalized in the twentieth century by theories of “significant form” or “art for art’s sake.”⁵⁰ South Asian temples and images have become works of art through similar acts of conceptual abstraction, formalist purification and re-classification (including in some cases, physical appropriation), by socially powerful regimes of scholarly and institutional authority.⁵¹ They are re-made into objects that, although they exist here-and-now, are imaginatively treated *as if* they are bounded entities that, as the price of authenticity, must continue to exist in their own pasts, specifically in the richly mythologized moment of their creation.

Does that mean that temples and images should not function as art, or museum pieces, collectables, or destinations for sightseeing? Should they be suspended in some alternative (equally mythical) context of purified, indigenous authenticity in which only native voices have authority? I think

49 The relation of the Peoples of the Book to graven imagery is not a simple story of absolute rejection. This generalization is not intended diminish the historical uncertainties, complexities and ambiguities of such struggles.

50 The historical transformations of the art concept in the twentieth century is a vast and complex matter. Here I only indicate one thread of the tapestry relevant to the current discussion.

51 As described by James Clifford in *The Predicament of Culture: Twentieth-century Ethnology, Literature, and Art* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1988), 215–29.

not. The art concept has many strong points of similarity to analogous South Asian categories of *śilpa* and *kalā*, both of which have undergone significant modifications in meaning during the twentieth century as they have been juxtaposed and reinterpreted in light of evolving Western redefinitions of “art.” For good or ill, historical forces have shaped them into the semiotic resources of trans-national dialogues. Their ongoing re-valorizations by South Asians and others are a critical part of their vitality and continued relevance.

By appropriating ancient South Asian objects as “art,” certain implicit or underdeveloped usages and connotations of their forms have been intensified while others – indeed, the vast majority – have been stripped away, requiring them to be partially re-invented as essentialized, inherent (*e.g.* explicit iconological or dictionary-like) “meanings,” often of the artist’s or patron’s-intention sort that can be easily entered in a catalog, or efficiently inscribed on a museum label. In this way, as Clifford memorably puts it, such objects are made to enter elite contemporary art contexts “trailing clouds of authentic (traditional) culture.”⁵² Twentieth-century scholarly visions of the meanings of South Asian art objects have become consequently more rigorous – fixed, abstracted, textually bounded and overly precise – than would be warranted if one grants space for ethnographic evidence of living practices, where meanings tend to be more equivocal, fluid, multiple, unbounded and thus open to the influence of shifting points of view and changing environments.

Seen through ethnographic points of view, framed by their ritualized production and use, temples are empowered *remnants* of lived activities. Through the manner of their becoming they are made pregnant with the values and realities that such activities encode for their participants. Patrons, makers and users of Hindu temples and images treat them less like inert art objects and more like sacred ash (*vipūti*), blessed substances (*piracatam*), or *saṃskāras*: preparations, making well, forming impressions . . . Images do not appear as a point of arrival; they are not fixed by either the discrete moment of their creation or the final authority of authorial intentions. They are the waxing moon. They are seeds, harvested remnants of the previous season of growth, potentials for the next. They must grow and develop through human nurturing in order for their potentials to be realized for human ends, especially those of the householder. When surrounded by the concrete pragmatics of farming, family, business, prestige, health, and personal identity, a South Asian temple is as perpetually unfinished as the projects of its supporters.

52 Clifford, 225.

On the surface this account could possibly be misinterpreted as a token of the anthropological sin of representing the Other in an ahistorical ethnographic present. Indeed, have I not suggested that incompleteness in modern or Nayak times is the same as that of Chola or Pallava periods? Must an account of the past privilege discrete, temporal discontinuities, in order to be truly historical?

Over the past two hundred years of academic disciplinary study it has been amply demonstrated that (with difficulty) it is possible to selectively mine and massage the material remnants of ancient South Asian practices such that they may be re-cast into narratives that encode temporal sensibilities quite different than those through which they were apparently generated. The editorial emphasis placed on signs that can be construed as markers of discontinuous change presumes that the history being made is inscribed on an otherwise static temporal background. In other words, that human existence tends to be more or less timeless, conservative, uneventful (i.e. without history) unless interrupted by something more or less unprecedented that makes change happen. No doubt this is a reasonable and appealing model for representing the past. Especially in aesthetically heroic flavors, with tales of conquest, invention, discovery or other such actions that mark a break with the past. It is not my intention here to disparage or invalidate history in this sense, but to endorse an ongoing discussion of valid alternatives. If one takes models grounded in discontinuous change as the only valid historical form, then any temporal practices and sensibilities that do not conform to it – such as those I encountered among South Indian temple builders and their patrons – are liable to be judged as illustrating an absence. To say that this local mode of temporal action is ahistorical is to mis-recognize it as the binary opposite of a needlessly narrow conception of history.

As a local mode of historical practice, *samskara*, ritual trace-making, tends to be person-centric, memorial and metaphorically spiralling in trajectory. It tends also to be directed toward pragmatic and concrete aims: improved futures for the specific people involved. This mode of temporal action values repeatable forms that actively construct (or impose, if you prefer) temporal continuities configured against a presumed background of relentless – and potentially dangerous or unpredictable – changes. Here change is not taken as something that needs to be made by human agency, but more like a hydraulic flow that can be channelled by it. Within a field of always-forming, ever incomplete potentialities for the future, the material practices of temple construction and image making are implicitly organized so as to form well, to make perfect, to make preparations...

Thus, this account is admittedly ahistorical if judged from a narrow range of tolerance for what can be labelled historical. Outside that range it can alternatively be read as a sympathetic representation of a locally distinct form of historical practice – more concretely identified as a mode of physical trace-making – that is significantly (but of course not entirely) valorized by the production of long-term continuities within an otherwise relatively unstable field of action.

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